

Life and Love in Vizag

A feisty Farahad Zama chooses a south Indian Muslim family as his first novel's setting

| By Geeta Doctor |



THE MARRIAGE
BUREAU FOR
RICH PEOPLE

by FARAHAD ZAMA

Abacus

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Mr Hyder Ali could be a close relative of Botswana's most famous detective, the redoubtable Mma Ramatswe of *The No. 1 Ladies Detective Agency* by Alexander McCall Smith. He's got the same grit and can-do spirit of Ramatswe. Just like her, Mr Ali, a retired government clerk from the remote coastal city of Vizag, or Visakhapatnam, of Andhra Pradesh has been forced to reinvent himself. He does so by setting up a marriage bureau in the veranda of his small house under the eyes of his wife, Mrs Ali. She a practical woman who keeps a sharp eye on his ventures, with one hand stirring the pots in the kitchen and the other graciously bringing in glasses of cool water to his clients as the situation requires. She is both a Jeeves and a Watson to him. Together they make Mr Ali's agency the No. One Marriage Bureau for Rich People, as he has billed it.

Farahad Zama, as a first time author, who now lives in London, has traced the memory of his hometown with the light touch of a Kalamkari artist, using a traditional Persian kalam or pen to create the richly decorated wall-hangings that are traditionally made in the nearby areas. Mrs Ali adds her notes at the end for those who might not have heard of the attractions, both ancient and more recent, that Vizag has to offer. If some of these sound like instructions on how to decipher the more arcane portions of how exactly the caste system works, what a south Indian Muslim family eats for breakfast and how to make a typical semolina halwa, it only adds to the endearing quality of the narra-

tive. This is another aspect of India, perhaps one that does not make it to the headlines, that is mothballed into our deepest recesses of memory and that has to be taken out every now and then if only to remind us that it does exist.

It may have the trappings of a Disney-type fantasy, particularly when Aruna, Mr Ali's assistant, like Cinderella meets her prince who woos her in a mango orchard where the finest Banganapalle mangoes grow, but we are happy enough to go along with it. Part of Zama's skill is in making the things he knows best seem real enough for us to accept the fairy-tale ending. His descriptions of a fabulous wedding feast that one

of Mr Ali's successful clients organises and the moment when the sealed edges of the huge cauldron of biryani are opened by Musa, the biryani maestro, makes us savour the moment when as he puts it. "A vast amount of steam arose from the cauldron, bringing with it an aroma of cooking rice, meat, ghee and spices. Everybody stopped and all eyes were on the chef as he dug a big spatula into the food and took a

sample of the biryani." It's in the detailing of such vignettes that the book revels.

There is also a sub-plot involving the son of the Alis, who is part of a group protesting the setting up of an SEZ in an area owned by the local farmers. Mr Ali, who has been the epitome of tact and understanding to the marital hunters who arrive at his doorstep, cannot sympathise with his son's aspirations. It just adds a bit of spice to the cauldron of memories that Zama serves up with the style and zest and makes it just the right gift for the season.



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